

CITY UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG, DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC AND INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS SEM A, A.Y. 2026/27

# COMPARATIVE POLITICS AND SOCIETIES

## PIA2050 | WEEK 2: RESEARCH PROGRAMS/TRADITIONS

# LAST CLASS/TODAY'S CLASS

Comparative Politics is a discipline that focuses on the internal or the domestic politics of any country in the world, which entails the study of political actors, political institutions, and political processes. It is one of Political Science's main subfields.

"Comparativists" use evidence/observation for the purposes of "description" (i.e., to describe differences and similarities across various political systems) and "explanation" (i.e., developing/testing theories that study the causes/consequences of particular outcomes/phenomena, or their variation across time/space).

Today, we go over the history of Comparative Politics and look at the field's main "research programs" or "traditions of inquiry." We will conclude with an overview of the principles that should guide the way we go about explaining particular phenomena—in particular, through the development of so-called "theories."

# THE FIELD'S PAST

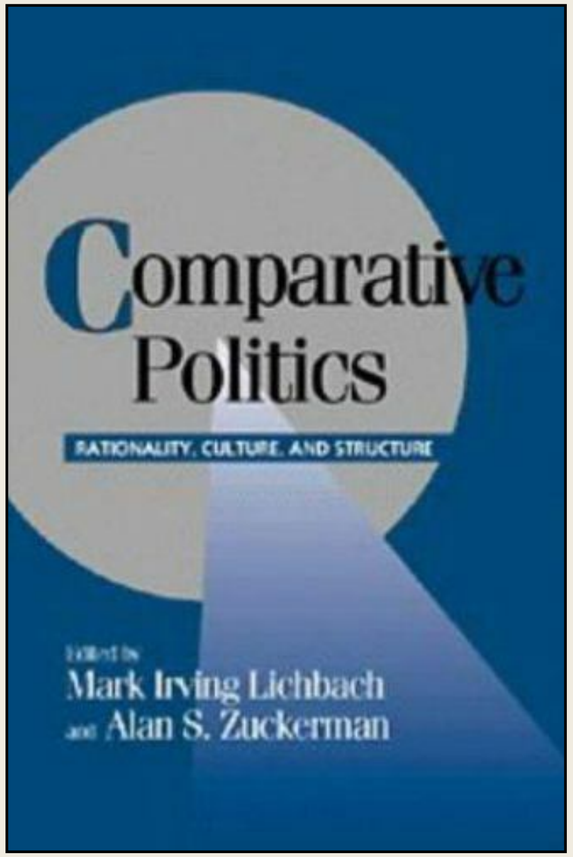
Initially, C.P. was mainly preoccupied with the descriptive comparison of different countries' domestic legal structures. In the 1950s, it adopted a more explanatory (causal), less formal/legalistic focus, based on the recognition that a nation's laws do NOT tell us anywhere close to the complete story of how politics works in that nation. Also, comparativists acquired greater theoretical/methodological sophistication. Why the switch? The main reasons:

(i) The so-called "behavioral revolution" in the social sciences coincided with greater interest in real/informal politics and greater popularity of game theory and statistical methods, while technological advances made statistical analysis more accessible to scholars and students;

(ii) Changes in geo-political context, esp. the American determination to win the Cold War and understand the causes of Hitler's rise/ World War 2.

# THE FIELD TODAY

Recall what we mentioned last week—Lichbach and Zuckerman (1997) described Comparative Politics as being characterized by:




* Ambitious scope of inquiry: no political phenomenon is foreign to it, no level of analysis is irrelevant to it, no time period is beyond its reach.
* Ambitious intellectual visions: practitioners approach events/cases with general questions in mind, not for their own sake.
* Concern for the "big questions" of social thought.

# THE BIG QUESTIONS

What accounts for the failure of state- and/or nation-building processes? Why are some countries democratic, while others are still ruled by despotic, authoritarian regimes? How do political institutions develop over time? How do institutions such as the form of government, the electoral system, and federalism affect a country's political life, its stability, and its prosperity? Can certain desirable outcomes be "engineered" through the design of the right institutions? What brings people to participate in politics? Why do some societies exhibit greater levels of political protest than others? What explains the intensity of the inter-group conflicts that define a country's politics? How can the rivalry between ethnic and other identity-based groups be kept from spiraling into violence? And how does a country's politics affect its levels of economic development? These questions—and others like them—will be tackled as part of this course's wide-ranging introduction to the study of comparative politics and societies.

—From the course outline

# MAIN APPROACHES

Lichbach and Zuckerman (1997) identified three main approaches or traditions (or "research programs") in Comparative Politics:

* Rationalist
* Structuralist
* Culturalist

Not exactly "theories," but "schools of thought" sharing basic assumptions, tools/strategies of inquiry, and perspectives on behavior/political reality.

There is great variation in the way scholars within each of these traditions go about their work; also, a great many attempts have been made to synthesize or combine these approaches in order to produce better explanations of particular cases or phenomena.

# STRUCTURALISTS

Deeply influenced by the work of Karl Marx, above all his "historical materialism."

"Historical materialism" is based on the assumption that the evolution of a country's social and political organization—indeed, the progression of history as a whole—is driven by changes in material conditions like relations of production, class structure, and available technologies.

Let's watch this video on Marx's "historical materialism:"

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gR3igiwaeyc&t

For even more in-depth treatments, which address "historical materialism" in the broader context of the scientific study of history, see the following (at home):

(i) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_AvvqDk-hME
(ii) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lVWwwfcQ5FA

# STRUCTURALISTS

Based on an adaptation of "historical materialism," structuralists assume that social life and individual actions are shaped by macro-level processes.

The most important among the processes most responsible for shaping interests/identities are those accounting for the so-called "large-scale features of modernity:" capitalist development, the diffusion of markets, technological change, state formation, nation-building.

Note that this is a largely "non-voluntaristic" approach: Social outcomes are assumed to be the result of impersonal, structural forces and of the sequencing of these processes, as opposed to being the result of individual decisions.

The behavior of the individuals involved depends on their relation to the structural forces and the collectivities/classes involved.

# STRUCTURALISTS

STRUCTURALISTS IN A NUTSHELL:

A country's social and political organization is determined by material conditions (relations of production, class structure/inequality, technologies). Political systems change as a result of structural change.

STRENGTH OF THE APPROACH:

The recognition that history is made in circumstances beyond the control of any of the individual participants, who face in the prevailing "structures" crucial constraints.

WEAKNESS OF THE APPROACH:

Underestimates the role of individual agency; overstates "inevitability" of outcomes based on "structure."

# CULTURALISTS

Culture is a system of meaning that people use to manage their daily worlds; it can be the basis of social and political identities that affect how people think and act.

Sharing a culture does not mean that those involved agree on all specifics; only that they possess a similar understanding of how the world works.

Several functions are typically ascribed to culture:

(1) Culture frames the context in which politics occurs, determining symbolic/material objects worth fighting over, setting the rules/norms by which politics takes place and the beliefs about (and organization of) community, authority, conflict;

(2) Culture links individual and collective identities: "identification" renders certain actions reasonable, removing alternatives that might be plausible on other grounds (such as one's self-interest);

# CULTURALISTS

Several functions ascribed to culture (continued):

(3) Culture defines group boundaries, organizes action by setting expectations of behavior/associations between and within groups;

(4) Culture provides a framework to interpret the actions and motives of others (motives are context-dependent; what one wants is determined by what's considered valuable in the society where the person lives);

(5) Culture offers resources for political organization and mobilization ("repertoires" of action are a "learned cultural creation").

Individual behavior is assumed to follow a "logic of (social) appropriateness:" People are motivated primarily by their desire to "fit in," or act in accordance with rules that define what is appropriate for a given person in a given situation, which are acquired through the process of (cultural) socialization.

# CULTURALISTS

CULTURALISTS IN A NUTSHELL:

A country's social and political organization is determined by its culture (influences rules/norms of politics and beliefs about political authority and institutions). Political systems change as a result of cultural change.

STRENGTH OF THE APPROACH:

"The logic of appropriateness" accounts for a great deal of individual behavior, as motivated by the desire to "fit in."

WEAKNESS OF THE APPROACH:

Understates "intentionality" of human behavior; overstates the "inevitability" of outcomes based on "culture." No mechanism for change.

# RATIONALISTS

Rationalists describe their approach as follows:

(i) The mission is to reveal how rational individual action generates collective action (sometimes with irrational consequences).

(ii) Emphasis is on the aggregation of individual action and the significance of interactions (actions taken in response to expectations about the behavior of others).

(iii) Recognition that choices take place in a context of uncertainty; individuals vary in their capacity to assess risk as well as their tolerance of risk. Often, "game theory" is used to model interactions.

(iv) Capacity to make sense of statistical correlations by providing a story identifying the causal mechanism responsible for causal relations ("micro-foundations").

(v) Attempt to uncover "laws" that are universally valid, regardless of time and space.

# RATIONALISTS

METHODOLOGICAL INDIVIDUALISM:

All social phenomena can/should be explained in terms of the actions of individuals operating under constraints (constraints on their knowledge, capabilities, resources, and behavior, imposed by the rules that structure social interactions). Collective action is produced by the aggregation of the decisions made by individuals; focus should be on the process by which we go from individual choice to social outcomes.

INSTRUMENTAL RATIONALITY:

Rationality is not about goals/tastes/preferences; it is about the means by which individuals pursue/satisfy preferences (and on the way they process beliefs), not limited to maximizing wealth or naked self-interest. Non-rational action is either: (i) Impulsive/visceral; or (b) Taken without regard for the consequences because of deeper psychological reason.

# RATIONALISTS

Responses to criticisms focusing on the approach's lack of realism:

- Famous economist Milton Friedman argued that it doesn't matter if individuals actually sit down and calculate how to maximize expected utility; what matters is that they act AS IF they do.
- Realism does matter, but rational choice only explains a subset of behavior: i.e., when the stakes are high and information is available.
- Over time, the process of trial and error should lead to convergence in expectations/outcomes in high stakes situations. Alternatively, a natural selection argument may apply: i.e., actors who act irrationally in high stakes situation are gradually weeded out, leaving only rational actors to participate in those situations.

# RATIONALISTS

THE SEARCH FOR "EQUILIBRIUM:"

Attempt to explain how, in different situations, the interaction between individuals will produce stable social outcomes.

"Equilibrium" is defined as a situation where nobody has an incentive to change their decisions.

NASH EQUILIBRIUM: When two or more players interact in some "game," N.E. designates situation in which none has an incentive to change his/her actions given the actions of others. E.g.: "Prisoner's dilemma."

For an illustration, please watch the following:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jUTWcYXVR5w

# RATIONALISTS

THE LOGIC OF COLLECTIVE ACTION:

Rationalists often focus on the obstacles to collective action and on how such obstacles can be overcome.

Work on this topic is deeply influenced by Mancur Olson's (1965) book *The Logic of Collective Action*; the book's main contribution was to show that individuals with common interests don't always come together in organizations that advance those interests.

WHY? Because collective action is mostly about the provision of "public goods" (non-excludable; cannot discriminate between participant and free-rider in the distribution of public goods). As Olson (1965) pointed out, it's often the case that our personal interests are in contrast with group interests.

# RATIONALISTS

Why? People care about “public goods,” but they also have an interest (a private interest) in maximizing income, saving time, conserving energy, etc.

And, if the group sharing a common interest in providing a “public good” is large, each individual member has no effect on whether the group will succeed or fail in providing it.

Each individual in the group, that is, will enjoy or not enjoy the public good depending on whether the group succeeds or fails, irrespective of his/her individual participation. Therefore, individuals have an incentive to “free ride” and wait for others to act; and, if everyone thinks this way, nobody will act.

Common solutions are said to include: (i) Coercion; (ii) Selective incentives.

To recap: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Bs8IFXYA6d8

# RATIONALISTS

RATIONALISTS IN A NUTSHELL:

A country's social and political organization is determined by individuals pursuing their self-interest; specific outcomes hinge on whether and on how the leaders of organized groups ("political entrepreneurs") solve the "collective action problem."

STRENGTH OF THE APPROACH:

Its focus on individual agency and on the intentionality of human beings.

WEAKNESS OF THE APPROACH:

Incomplete view of people's motivations; unrealistic assumptions about the way people form their beliefs and make decisions.

# CRITIQUE

Rationalists are pretty good at explaining why people do not participate in collective action, but they're not as good at explaining actual participation. Different answers to this criticism:

- Rationalists are mostly right, as most people most of the time don't participate in collective action (political or otherwise). Fair enough, but the theory is still irrelevant to explaining participation.
- People participate because of "social incentives" (prestige, respect, friendship, good time). Ok, but what about activities where the other participants are not known?
- People participate because of "psychological incentives" (it makes them feel good). That's probably true, but at the risk of "tautology:" if one can explain anything and everything as "rational," how can it ever be shown otherwise? The theory is no longer "falsifiable."

# THE PARADOX OF VOTING

Why is voting a "paradox?" Because it should not happen, if people acted "rationally:" Voting involves private costs (generally minor), while the chance that any particular individual will cast a deciding vote is basically nil.

And yet, voting does happen, regularly and in massive numbers, and sometimes at great cost and even risk of personal injury.

So why does voting happen? Because many people have a sense of civic duty that creates a sort of moral obligation to participate in elections (or obey the laws of the land, even if it's inconvenient at times); also, voting has some psychological benefits people experience in exchange for doing their "duty" or for expressing themselves.

Does that make voters "irrational?" Hardly, but it makes rationalism not terribly useful in explaining what is a pretty important issue.

# AN ALTERNATIVE

Political theorist Jon Elster (2007) agrees with rationalists that explanations in the social sciences should refer only to individuals—that all collective behavior is the aggregate result of individual actions/decisions.

But, individuals often do not act according to the requirements of "instrumental rationality;" rather, Elster suggests we interpret action by looking at the beliefs and desires (motivations) of the agents.

Emotions may at times be strong enough to crowd out all other considerations; even when emotional impulses are resistible, visceral cravings might block out the process of deliberation. Most behavior is driven by visceral factors in part, but is sensitive to costs and benefits.

Cites three motivations: (1) INTEREST: Pursuit of personal advantage; (2) PASSION: Visceral urges; (3) REASON: Desire to promote the public good.

# AN ALTERNATIVE

Different motives are often in conflict. Because every society/culture has a normative hierarchy of motives, interests and passions often show some deference to reason, or are tempered by the desire to care about reason (or appear as though one does).

Reason might in some cases serve as justification for action already decided on other grounds. And, in some instances, the search for a justification grounded in reason might actually change one's behavior.

The main point is that explanations in the social sciences should feature an attempt to establish the beliefs and motives of individuals, independent of the action they took or the outcomes thereof.

Intentional, goal-oriented behavior can only be made intelligible with reference to the agent's underlying motivations/desires and the beliefs that induced the agent to take a certain course of action over another in order to satisfy the goal in question.

# REFERENCES


Elster, Jon. 2007. *Explaining Social Behavior: More Nuts and Bolts for the Social Sciences*. Cambridge University Press.

Lichbach, Mark I. and Alan S. Zuckerman (eds). 1997. *Comparative Politics: Rationality, Structure, and Culture*. Cambridge University Press.

Olson, Mancur. 1965. *The Logic of Collective Action*. Harvard University Press.